

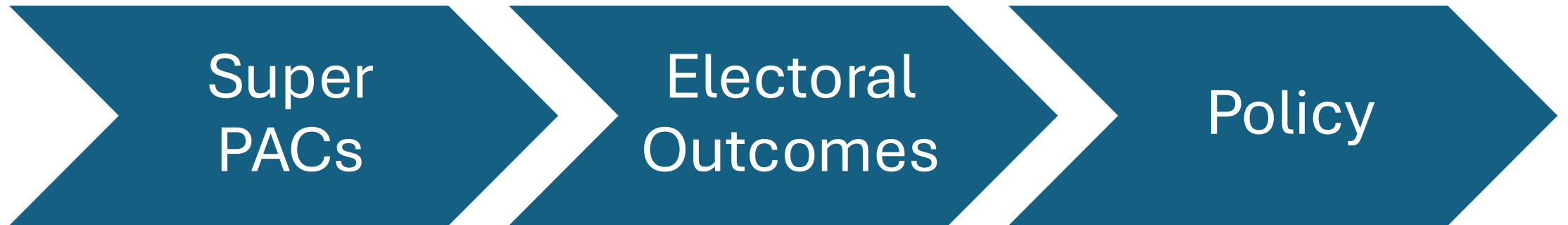
Measuring the effect of super PACs on minority representation in local elections

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Motivation

- The rise of super PACs increased the influence of wealthy donors
- In the U.S. context, wealthy donors tend to be more white and male than voters (Barber)
- The impact of super PACs on local elections has been understudied due to a lack of comprehensive local election data
- American local government elections database, published in 2023, enables studying super PACs' impact on local elections

How super PACs affect local policy



Feasible thanks to American
local government elections
database

Infeasible due to lack of a
comprehensive local policy
database in an easily readable
format (Municode requires NLP)

Research questions

- How do super PACs affect the probabilities of minority candidates competing, entering, and winning?
 - (Race x Gender x Party) Does the effect size vary by different combinations of race, gender, and party membership?
 - (Partisanship) Does the effect size vary by partisan competitiveness?
 - (Office) Does the effect size vary by office?

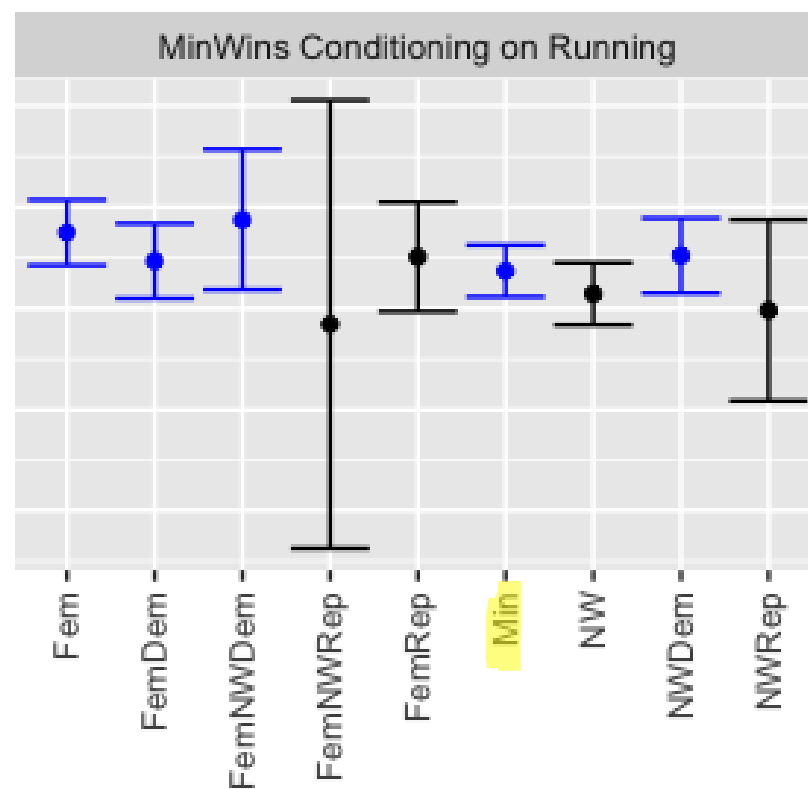
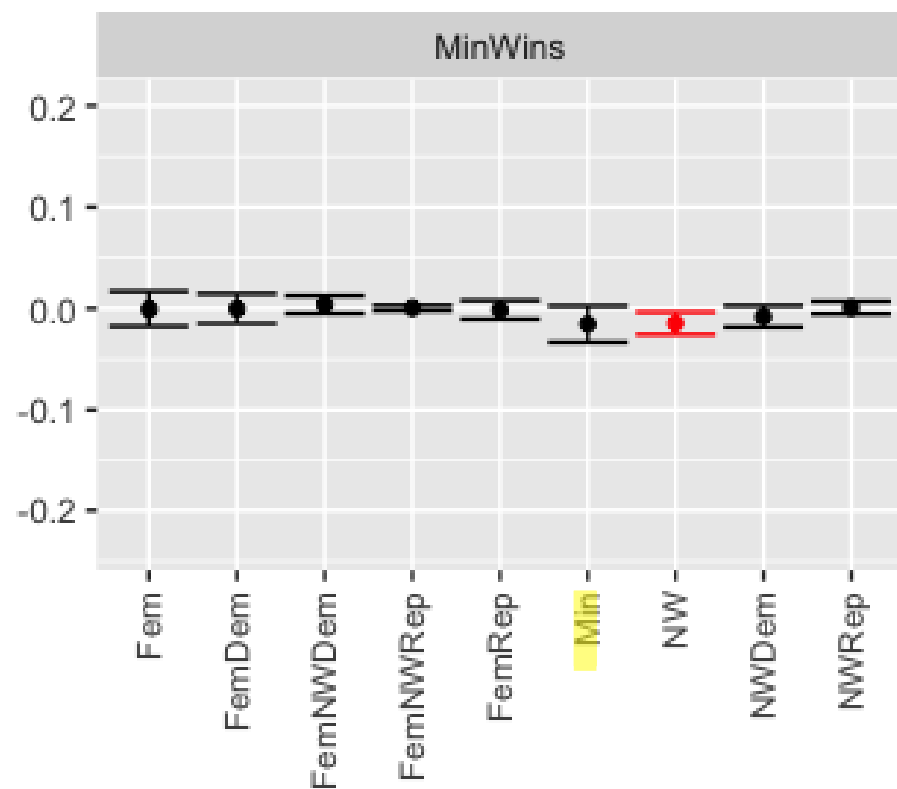
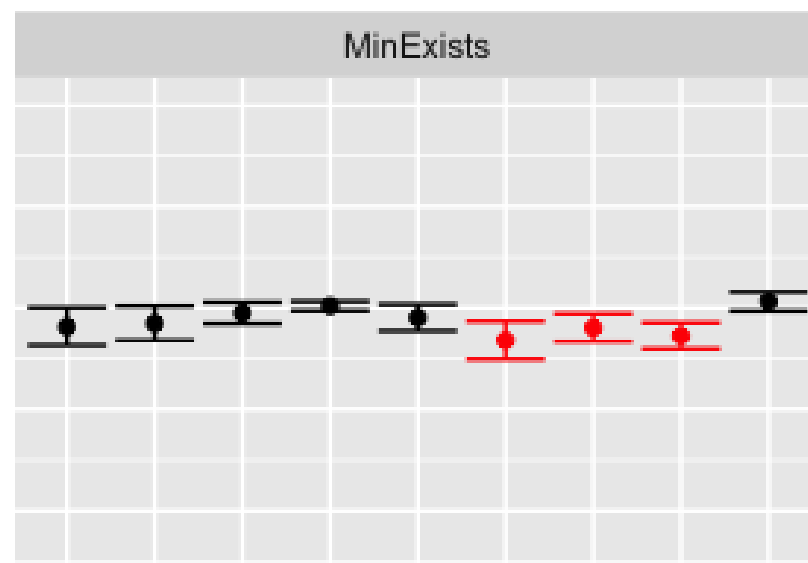
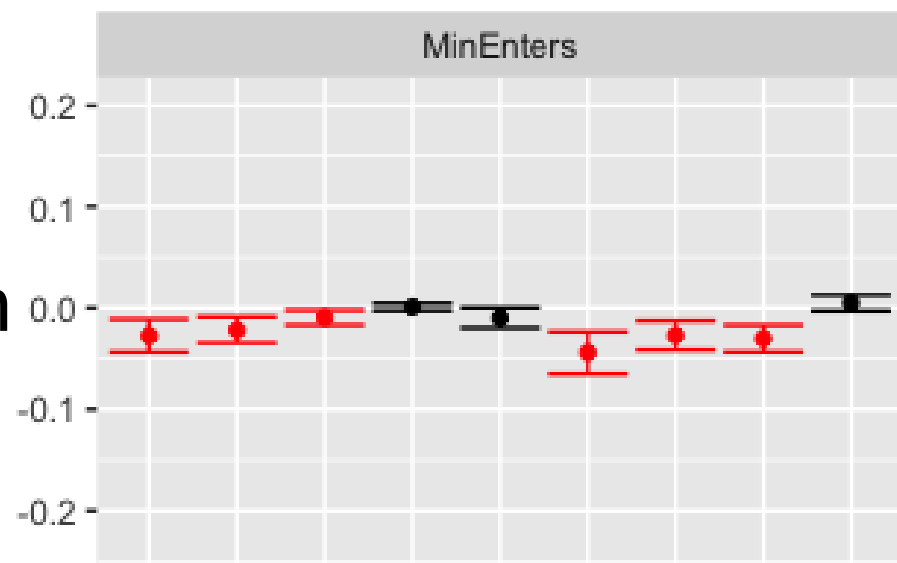
Data

- Source: American local government elections database
- 43,498 local elections b/w 2000-2020
 - (Office) 39% county legislatures, 32% city council, 9% prosecutor, 7% sheriff, 6% mayor, 5% school board, 1% county executive
 - (Partisan) 41% partisan
 - (Minority) 53% with minority candidates (40% with female candidates; 30% with non-White candidates)

Research design

- Diff-in-Diff two-way fixed effects
- Unit of Analysis: each race
- $Y_{ct} = \beta CityUni * BanState + Contest_c + Year_t + \varepsilon_{ct}$
 - $Y \in \{MinExists, MinEnters, MinWins, MinWinsWhenRunning\}$
 - *Treatment: CityUni (binary)*BanState (binary)*
 - *Contest = StateXLocalityXDistrictXOffice*
 - *i.e.) City of Los Angeles Council District 10*

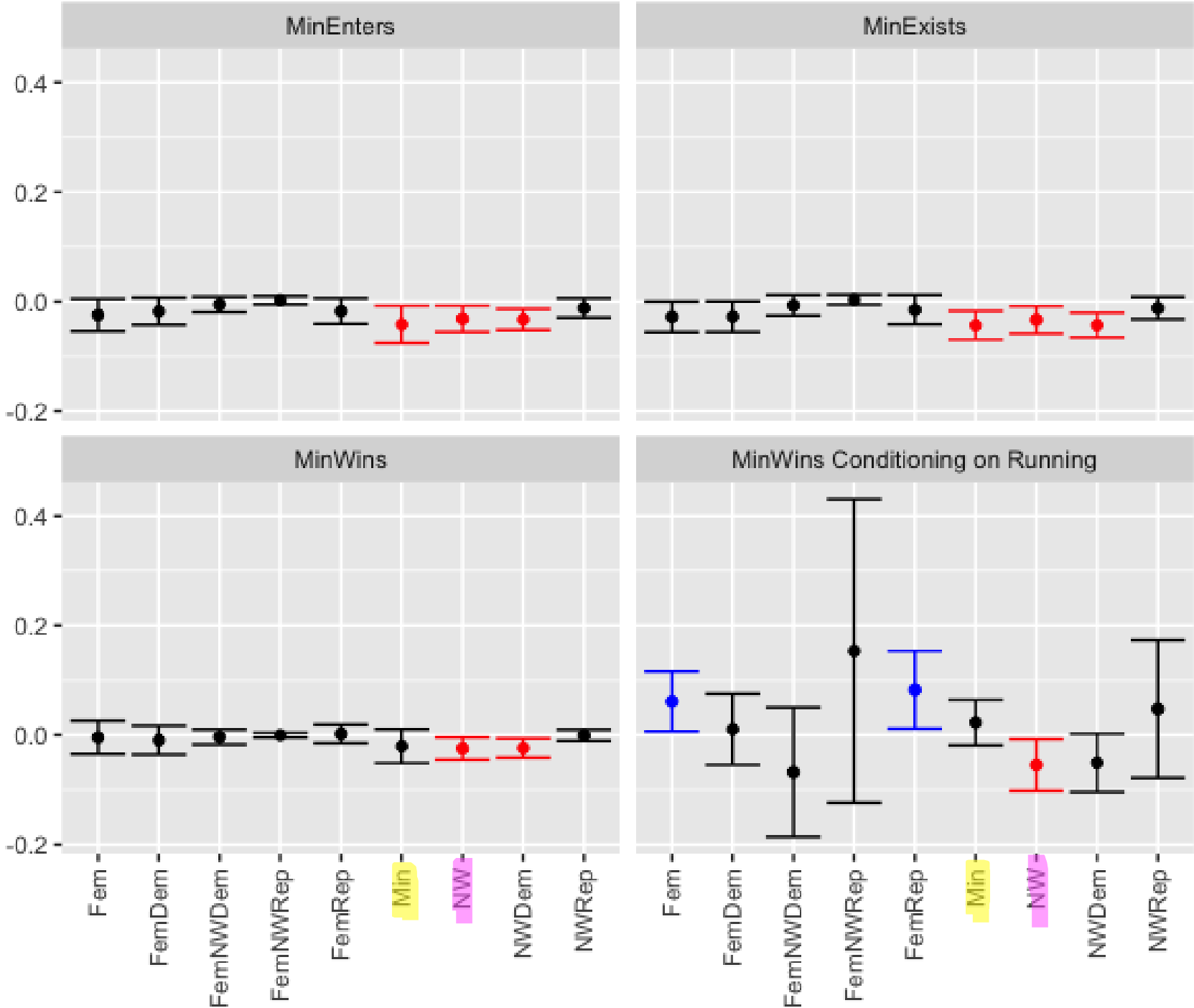
Both
partisan and
non-partisan
contests



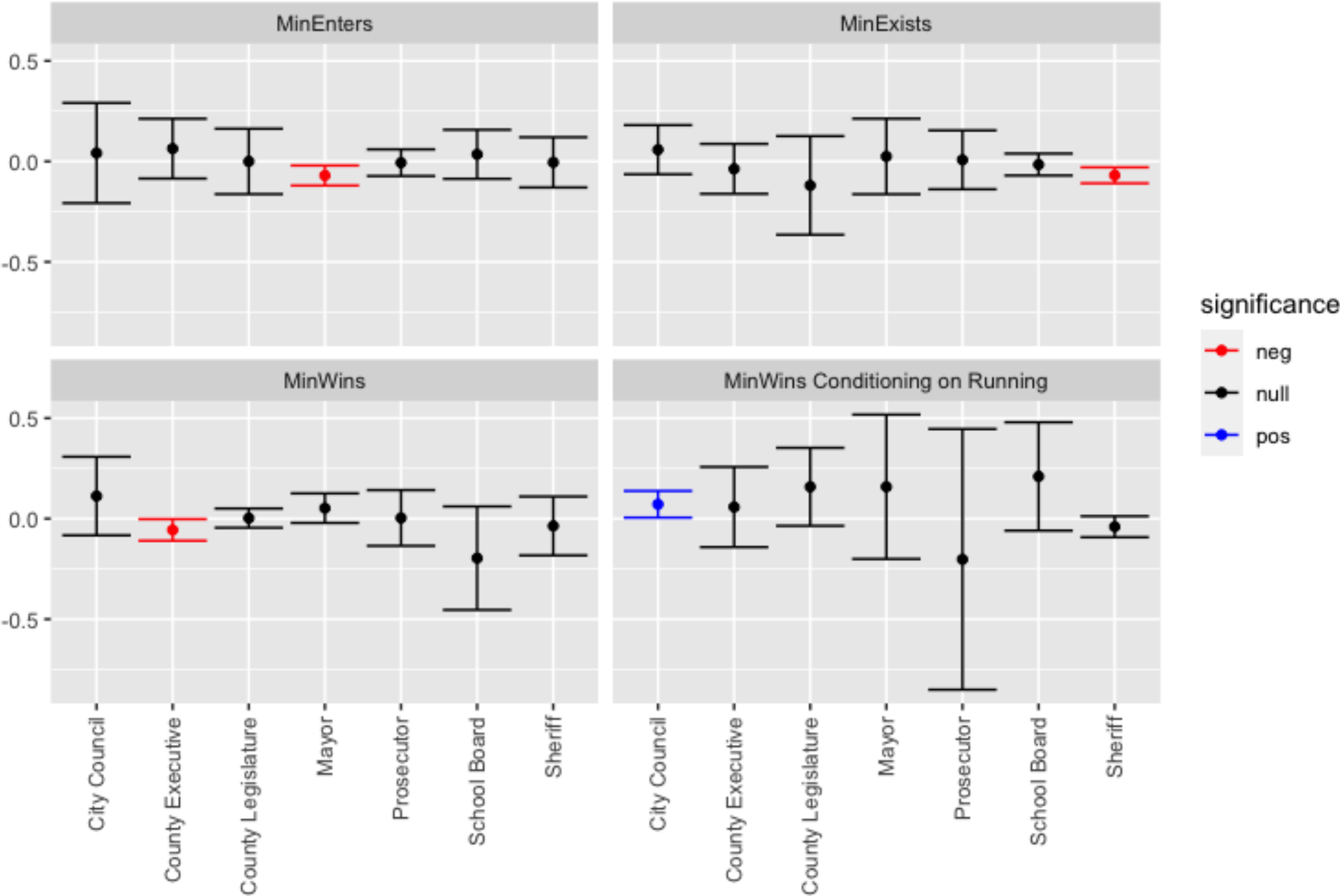
significance

- neg
- null
- pos

Partisan
contests only

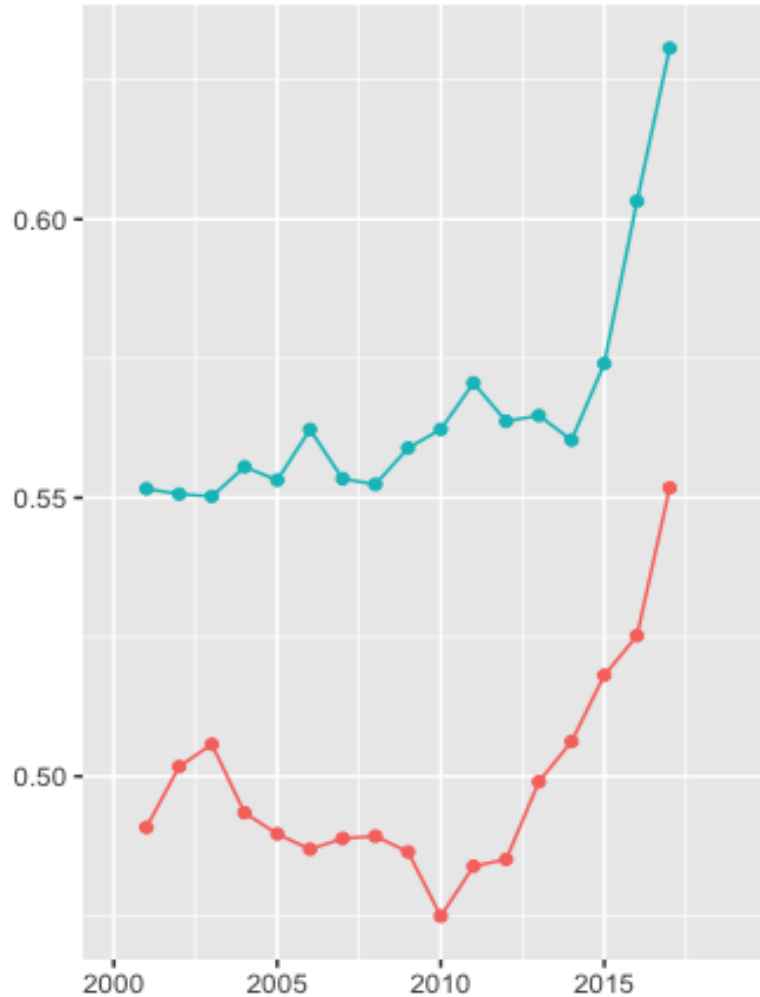


Effect
by office

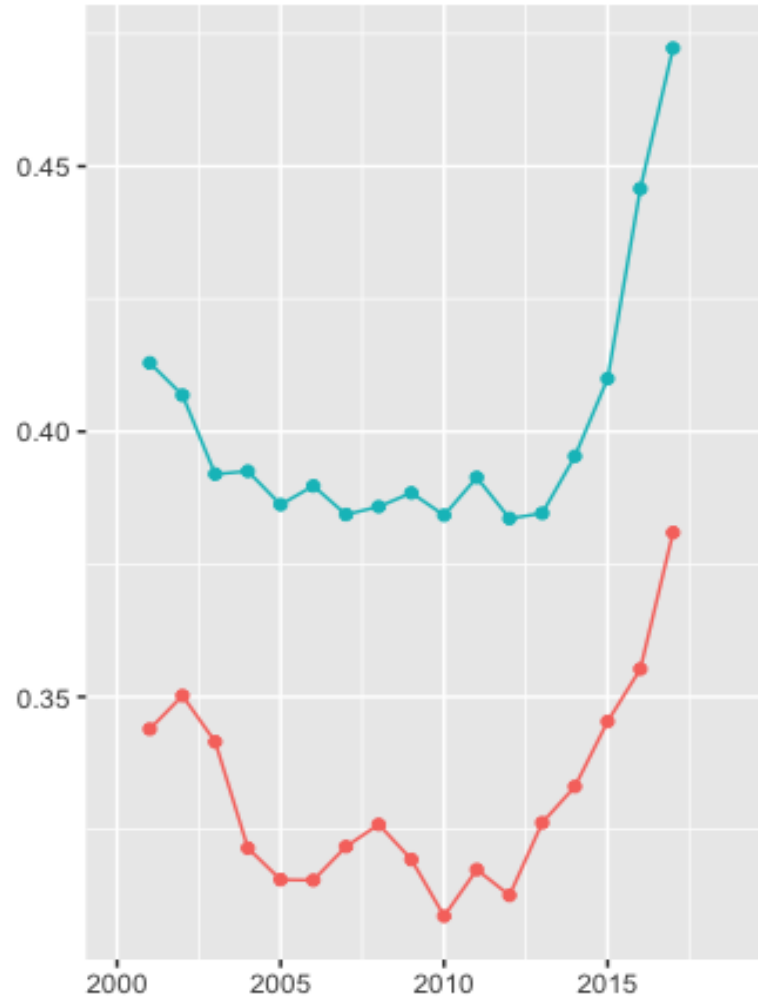


Parallel trend assumption

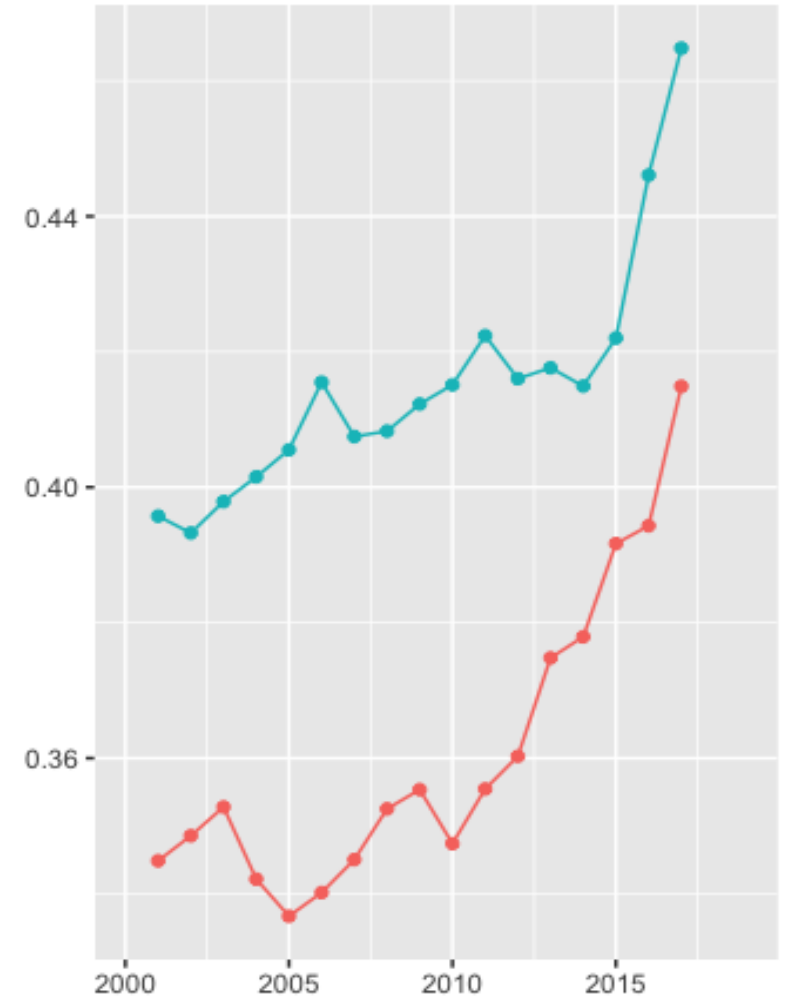
% of Races with Minority Candidates (·)



% of Races with Minority Enterances (·)



% of Races with Minority Winners (4-y)



Questions

- Research design
 - Does the **parallel trend assumption** hold? Should I use a synthetic control design instead?
 - What is the right unit to **cluster standard errors**? Locality or state?
- Interpretation
 - I interpret the main findings as that super PACs increase the probability of minority winning conditional on running because only extremely qualified minority candidates run due to a higher barrier. Do you agree with this interpretation?
 - Does the **heterogeneous effect** by office make sense?
- Further measurement
 - How can I measure the **quality** of local candidates?
 - How can I measure the **policy preferences** of local candidates?